Script for Guided Meditation

Introduction to Happiness and Joy

Through our meditation practice, we can consciously cultivate the natural well-being and joy that we were born with. Using mindful attention, we can directly experience the aliveness of genuine well-being in the body, mind, and heart as we connect with the goodness inside and around us. To access this natural joy, we don't merely know we're feeling good; *we actually feel what it's like to feel good*.

Without efforting to make something happen, we can invite well-being and joy by simply inclining our mind in that direction as we connect with what brings us delight and appreciation, letting ourselves mindfully relax into it when it is here. Our own well-being and joy can be a gift to others as it awakens those qualities in those around us.

Script for Meditation (15 minutes)

Find a comfortable posture in which you can feel both alert and relaxed. Let yourself feel grounded and supported by the earth . . .

Start with a relaxing body scan. As you move your awareness through the body, invite each area to soften if there's any tension . . . allow your face to soften—your forehead, your eyes, your jaw . . . soften down through your neck, your shoulders, your arms . . . continue down through your torso, softening your chest and belly . . . down through your pelvic region and hips . . . continue down your legs—your thighs, knees, lower legs . . . through your ankles, feet, and toes. Allow your whole body to relax and be at ease . . .

Allow a half-smile to form on your face with a slight upcurling of the lips . . . Notice how this affects your mind . . .

Take a few deeper breaths, bringing a calming energy to your body with each in-breath and inviting further relaxation as you let go with each out-breath . . .

Now allow the breath to find its own natural rhythm . . . Let the breath breathe you, without you needing to control it or make anything happen. Simply relax and receive the breath as it moves through you.

Now bring to mind something that brings you joy . . . What brings you joy or a feeling of contentment and well-being? Perhaps being out in nature, in a forest or by a lake. Maybe dancing or being with a loved one or a pet . . . Recall a time when you experienced this well-being. Without trying to make anything happen, just relax and enjoy the memory. Notice how it feels in your body as you recall the experience . . . How does it feel in your mind? . . . Notice how it feels in your heart. Let your awareness rest in this feeling of well-being . . . (longer pause)

Take a deep breath . . .

Now bring to mind some blessing in your life—someone or something you're grateful for or grateful to . . . As you think of this blessing, bring an image to your mind of this person, being, or circumstance . . . Now give a simple, silent "thank you" right from your heart to that being or to life . . . Relax in the joyful feeling of gratitude as it pervades your body . . .

Take a deep breath and bring to mind another blessing—someone or something you're grateful for or grateful to . . . Once again bring an image to mind of this person, being, or circumstance . . . Give a silent "thank you" from your heart . . . Relax and let yourself enjoy this feeling in your body . . .

Take another longer breath . . . Bring to mind a third blessing . . . Call up an image of this person, being, or life situation . . . Give a silent "thank you" and let yourself enjoy the feeling of gratitude . . .

Take another deep breath . . .

Now open to the fact that you are alive. As you relax, feel life as it moves through you, without you needing to make anything happen . . . Be aware of this breath that is sustaining you and keeping you alive . . . be aware of the blood flowing throughout your body, nourishing every cell . . . your senses taking in colors, sounds, fragrances, and tastes and making sense of the world . . . Become aware of all the miraculous bodily processes that are keeping you alive right now . . .

Now become aware of consciousness itself shining through you . . . Let yourself relax and receive life as it moves through this form called you . . . (long pause) . . . nothing you need to do . . . Let yourself simply enjoy the fact that you are alive . . .

As we come to the end of this meditation, let yourself slowly open to your surroundings, taking in all the goodness inside and around you with appreciation and joy.